

CORE FORMULA

Notice the good news -> show real interest -> name a specific positive part -> ask one energising follow-up -> stay with their answer. -> That is genuinely good news - what was the best part of it? -> That is a proper milestone. What moment made it feel real? -> You worked hard for that. How did you find out? -> That sounds like a real win - what made it land for you?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Catch the good news, resist the reflexive "nice", and say one warm, specific line with a single follow-up: "That is genuinely good news - what was the best part of it?"

BEST FOR

- Good news and wins
- Promotions and milestones
- Relief after a hard stretch
- Creative or personal progress
- Moments when someone is quietly testing whether you will share their joy
- Rebuilding warmth after a run of flat, distracted responses

PHRASE BANK

Quick reactions · Short openers

- "That's brilliant."
- "Oh, that's the best news."
- "What a result."
- "Genuinely pleased for you."
- "That's a proper win."
- "I love that for you."
- "That made my day."
- "Well deserved, that."

Digital / text · One clean line

- "That's brilliant news - genuinely pleased for you."
- "Amazing. Tell me how it happened when you've got a sec."
- "That's such good news to wake up to."
- "So happy for you - what's the first thing you did?"
- "Been hoping this would come through for you. Congratulations."
- "This deserves more than a thumbs-up - properly well done."

Share the joy · Warmth and feeling

- "That's lovely - you must be so pleased."
- "You worked hard for that."
- "That's worth enjoying for a second."
- "I'm really glad this landed for you."
- "You've earned this one."
- "I can see how much this means to you."
- "That's the kind of news that makes your week."

Energising follow-ups · One good question

- "What was the best part of finding out?"
- "What made it land for you?"
- "Who did you tell first?"
- "What's the first thing you did?"
- "What moment made it feel real?"
- "What are you most pleased about?"
- "How did it actually happen?"
- "What's next now this has come through?"

Professional wins · Work and results

- "Landing that is a real result - what made the difference?"
- "That's a strong outcome. What are you most pleased with?"
- "Big milestone for the team - how did it come together?"
- "That's worth marking properly. What was the turning point?"
- "Genuinely good work on that. What are you taking from it?"
- "That's the sort of win that gets noticed. How does it feel?"

Guarded or mixed news · Low-pressure celebration

- "That's a good result - happy to hear more if you feel like sharing."
- "First things first - that's a real win. We can sort the rest after."
- "No pressure to make a thing of it, but I'm genuinely glad for you."
- "Sounds like good news with a catch - what's the good part first?"
- "Only if you want to get into it - how are you feeling about it?"
- "I don't want to overdo it, but quietly, well done."

Repair and soften · When it misses

- "I may have read that wrong - what's the honest version?"
- "Let me put that more simply."
- "No need to go there if it's not useful."
- "I jumped ahead there - sorry."
- "I don't want to make a bigger deal of it than you want."
- "We can leave that and come back to it if it helps."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Nice. Anyway, about the meeting...

Better: That's great news - what was the best part?

Best: That's a proper win. You've been working toward that for months - what was the moment you realised it had actually happened?

2. Weak: Nice one.

Better: Congrats! That's great.

Best: That's brilliant - you earned that. What's the first thing you did when you found out?

3. Weak: Well done.

Better: Well done, that's a big deal.

Best: Well done - I know how much the client side was worrying you, so getting that sign-off must feel great.

DECISION TREE

If They're still sharing the news

Don't interrupt; let them finish, then respond.

"Go on - what happened next?"

If You're not sure which part they're most pleased about

Check before you celebrate the wrong thing.

"What's the part that feels best to you?"

If The news is mixed or they seem unsure

Match their actual feeling rather than forcing enthusiasm.

"How are you feeling about it - pleased, or more complicated than that?"

If They lean in and expand

Stay with it; ask one more genuine question.

"What made it finally click?"

If They shrink, correct you, or go flat

Ease off and repair.

"I may have made more of that than you wanted - tell me where to land."

If They start hinting they want help or advice

Ask permission before switching from celebration to problem-solving.

"Do you want to think it through, or just enjoy it for now?"

SCENARIOS

Social conversation

Keep it warm and brief; share the feeling and ask one light follow-up. — "That's great - what's the first thing you did when you heard?"

Professional / work win

Name the specific achievement, then hand it back to them. — "Landing that account is a big deal - what made the difference in the end?"

Digital / text

Write one clean, specific line and avoid overexplaining. — "That's brilliant news - genuinely pleased for you. How did it come about?"

Guarded or high-status person

Make the celebration optional and low-pressure. — "That's a good result - happy to hear more if you feel like sharing."

Close relationship

Drop the technique feel; use ordinary, unpolished words. — "Oh, that's the best news - come here, tell me everything."

Mixed news (good with a catch)

Celebrate the good part first; hold the problem for later. — "First - that's a real win. We can sort the logistics after."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The person is ambivalent or clearly not celebrating
- The news has ethical or safety problems
- Strong enthusiasm would feel fake or forced
- They want privacy or containment, not a spotlight
- The move would add pressure, exposure or embarrassment
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the cue

Through the day, notice every time someone shares good news, however small. Just count them - don't change what you do yet.

Day 2 — Catch your default

Take five recent conversations and write how you actually responded to good news. Mark which were flat, which turned back to you, which shared the moment.

Day 3 — Write the move

For each of those five, write the one warm, specific line and single follow-up you could have used instead.

Day 4 — Say it plainly

Rehearse those lines aloud until they stop sounding scripted. Cut anything that sounds polished or performative.

Day 5 — One live rep

In a real conversation, respond to one piece of good news with interest, a specific note, and one follow-up. Then just listen

to the answer.

Day 6 — Read the response

Do it again, and this time watch the calibration cue - did they expand and relax, or shrink? Adjust in the moment.

Day 7 — Recover on purpose

Practise one recovery line after a response that lands flat, so repairing feels natural: "I may have read that wrong - what's the honest version?"

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I notice the good-news cue instead of talking over it?
- Did I keep the move short and specific?
- Did I share their feeling rather than redirect to myself?
- Did I ask one genuine follow-up and then listen?
- Did I watch their response and adjust?
- Did I repair quickly if it missed?